



How prior ties influence organizational behaviors and performance outcomes: A meta-analysis

Lihan Zhang^a, Bo Liu^a, Yongcheng Fu^{b,*}, Sujuan Zhang^c, Wenqian Guo^d

^a Hebei Key Laboratory of Digital Intelligent Management and Advanced Equipment for Complex Engineering, School of Economics and Management, Hebei University of Technology, Tianjin 300401, China

^b Laboratory of Computation and Analytics of Complex Management Systems (CACMS), College of Management and Economics, Tianjin University, Tianjin 300072, China

^c School of Project Management, John Grill Institute for Project Leadership, Faculty of Engineering, The University of Sydney, Sydney, NSW 2037, Australia

^d School of Economics and Management, Beijing Jiaotong University, Beijing 100044, China

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ABSTRACT

Repeated transactions between organizations significantly affect organizational behavior and performance. However, the literature on whether such prior ties are beneficial remains inconsistent. Conceptualizing organizational behaviors as cooperative and opportunistic behaviors and performance outcomes as relationship performance and satisfaction, this study meta-analyzed 371 relevant studies involving 101,053 interorganizational relationships. The moderating effects of institutional environments and mediating effects of contractual and relational governance were examined. Results showed that prior ties can generally enhance relationship performance and satisfaction, increase cooperative behaviors, and inhibit opportunistic behaviors. These relationships are moderated by institutional environments, including individualism/collectivism, uncertainty avoidance, and formal institutions. Contract design and relational governance partially mediate these relationships, whereas contract application has no mediating role. This study enriches the research on prior ties in business management and offers guidance for business managers in contingently selecting partners and improving governance mechanisms.

1. Introduction

Repeated transactions often occur in business management for reasons such as recognizing another party's competence, forming routines that facilitate communication, and avoiding the direct and indirect costs associated with finding new partners. Despite the frequent occurrence of prior ties, their advantages and disadvantages remain controversial, resulting in significant contradictions in the literature. For example, Wang et al. (2017) revealed the function of prior ties in promoting in- and extra-role cooperative behaviors. Wang et al. (2019) found that repeated transactions enable one party to effectively predict others' behaviors and thus prevent opportunism. However, some studies have also highlighted the disadvantages of repeated transactions. For example, Zhang et al. (2021) argued that prior ties may facilitate a party's speculative behaviors, as this party becomes knowledgeable of the other's important and sensitive information. Ren et al. (2024) also

supported the dark side of repeated transactions, that is, they stimulate sellers' opportunism under conditions of high task uncertainty or high dependence asymmetry.

Multiple reasons account for these inconsistencies, and they include the presence of moderating variables and diverse business management contexts. Recently, Wang et al. (2021) distinguished between the general and partner-specific experiences of strategic alliances and used a meta-analysis to examine how different experience types affect alliance performance. Nevertheless, "experience" in their research was not limited to the cooperation between two partners. Moreover, their research focused only on strategic alliances. Therefore, the first knowledge gap is that no business management study has integrated empirical evidence for repeated transactions, resulting in a lack of holistic interpretations of their influence.

Organizations are embedded in institutional environments, which serve as important situational factors in the interorganizational

* Corresponding author.

E-mail addresses: zhanglihan1106@163.com (L. Zhang), liu609370940@163.com (B. Liu), yongcheng_fu@126.com (Y. Fu), yyzhangsujuan@163.com (S. Zhang), gwq_tju@163.com (W. Guo).

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relationship management literature (Cao et al., 2018; Zhou & Poppo, 2010). Hence, institutional environments may constitute the boundary conditions for ties to work. However, no study has investigated its moderating role, and this deficiency forms the second knowledge gap. Moreover, when explaining organizational behaviors and performance outcomes, contractual and relational governance are important antecedents (Cao & Lumineau, 2015). Parties with prior ties also sign formal contracts when they re-transact while implementing informal relational governance. Nevertheless, no study has answered the question of whether these two governance mechanisms explain the “black box” underlying the relationship between prior ties and organizational behaviors/performance outcomes. This issue forms the third knowledge gap.

To fill the aforementioned gaps, this study conducts a meta-analysis and synthesizes empirical evidence to answer three research questions: (1) How do prior ties influence organizational behaviors and performance outcomes? (2) Does the institutional environment moderate these relationships? (3) Do contractual and relational governance mediate these relationships? This study deepens the understanding of prior ties in business management, enriches the boundary conditions for functioning from an institutional perspective, and explains the internal mechanisms by which prior ties affect organizational behaviors and performance outcomes. The findings provide a theoretical basis for business managers to select partners in different contexts and highlight the necessity of improving interorganizational governance mechanisms.

2. Theoretical background and hypothesis deduction

2.1. Prior ties

Prior ties are elsewhere called “prior links” (Sampson, 2007), “previous alliances” (Ahuja et al., 2009), “repeated partners” (Holloway & Parmigiani, 2016), “familiarity” (Ren et al., 2024), etc. In the early days, Gulati (1995) challenged the assumption of treating each transaction between firms as independent and pointed out that the governance structure in repeated alliances is different from that in one-time alliances. Subsequently, scholars have explored interorganizational repeated transactions. The relevant literature is mostly empirical and focuses on two aspects. Some studies have explained how such prior ties influence interorganizational governance mechanisms, such as contract design (Xing et al., 2021), contract enforcement (Chen et al., 2018), and trust (Chen et al., 2018). Other studies have explored the influence of prior ties on parties, such as cooperative behaviors (Wang et al., 2017) and opportunistic behaviors (Wuyts & Geyskens, 2005). As the introduction illustrates, many empirical controversies have arisen in the latter research stream. However, meta-analyses that aggregate the scattered empirical evidence are lacking. Therefore, this study endeavors to fill these gaps and add nuances to the relationships between prior ties and organizational behaviors/performance outcomes.

2.2. Prior ties and organizational behaviors/performance outcomes

Prior ties mean that two organizations have one or more contractual relationships or collaborations prior to the current transaction (Lee & Chong, 2021). The organizational behaviors in our study include cooperative and opportunistic behaviors. Cooperative behaviors refer to the coordinated actions taken by transactional parties to achieve mutual benefits (Lui et al., 2009). Repeated interactions provide parties with opportunities to learn each other's traits (Xie et al., 2023), thereby improving transaction efficiency. Interorganizational routines may develop through successive collaborations. These routines can incentivize parties to perform in line with each other's expectations and guide their commitments. A long transaction history enhances the level and scope of collaboration (Kim et al., 2010). Collaborative history also signals a party's reputation. Parties tend to make more commitments to maintain their reputations (Ryall & Sampson, 2009).

H1a: Prior interorganizational ties are positively related to cooperative behaviors.

Opportunism is “self-interest seeking with guile” (Williamson, 1975: 26). Prior exchange experiences are an important source of organizational learning. Owing to prior ties, parties can accumulate knowledge about each other, leading to a lower level of information asymmetry and an easier assessment of each other's behavior (Eisenhardt, 1989). This familiarity prevents parties from engaging in opportunism because misconduct can be easily detected and punished. Furthermore, by observing the behavioral patterns of the other party in previous collaborations, the party becomes more aware of its partner's integrity and behavioral preferences. This awareness helps understand and predict the other party's future behavioral patterns and speculative behaviors in which they may engage (Lioukas & Reuer, 2015). Thus, parties can take *ex-ante* appropriate measures to decrease and avoid speculative behaviors (Chen et al., 2018; Zhang et al., 2021).

H1b: Prior interorganizational ties are negatively related to opportunistic behaviors.

In our study, performance outcomes include satisfaction and relationship performance. Satisfaction captures a party's degree of satisfaction with the transaction performance (Cao & Lumineau, 2015). Prior ties can increase a party's knowledge of its partner, which strengthens its confidence in collaboration and thus enhances bilateral trust. Both social exchange and transaction cost theories predict that trust can be built over time through experience in transactions with known parties, although the logic and dimensions of trust differ in these theories (Chen et al., 2018). As a result of trust, parties are inclined to depend on each other (Luo, 2002; Yang et al., 2021). Such interdependence increases the parties' willingness to reciprocate and their commitment to bilateral relationships, thereby enhancing satisfaction.

H1c: Prior interorganizational ties are positively related to satisfaction.

Relationship performance refers to the parties' performance in terms of quality, cost, delivery, and so on. (Kim et al., 2023). As the number of collaborations increases, the parties are likely to develop cooperative routines tacitly. These routines are further strengthened and adapted each time a new collaborative contract is signed, resulting in smoother interaction patterns and problem-solving processes (Zollo et al., 2002) and enhanced relationship performance (Good & Schwegler Jr, 2022). Moreover, parties, particularly weak parties, are afraid of losing future cooperation opportunities if their performance is unsatisfactory. Hence, they may devote more resources and effort to enhancing their relationship performance, leaving them with more choices for future exchanges.

H1d: Prior interorganizational ties are positively related to relationship performance.

2.3. Moderating effects of institutional environments

The interorganizational relationship management literature has recognized institutional environments as important moderators, focusing mainly on formal institutions, that is, whether countries are developed or not (Zhou & Poppo, 2010). Meanwhile, the role of informal institutions remains largely unexplored. National culture is an important aspect of informal institutions (Peng et al., 2009). It is defined as collective planning shaped by shared beliefs and values that guide organizational behaviors in the social environment and influence interpretations of and responses to strategic issues (Hofstede, 2001). Our study focuses on three dimensions of national culture: individualism/collectivism, uncertainty avoidance, and power distance. They are widely recognized as key dimensions closely related to transaction risks and interorganizational relationship management (Cao et al., 2018;

Wang et al., 2021; Xie et al., 2023). In summary, the moderating variables include four types of institutional environments: individualism/collectivism, uncertainty avoidance, power distance, and formal institutions.

2.3.1. Individualism/collectivism

In a society characterized by individualism, individuals are loosely connected to each other and are expected to take care of themselves and their immediate family. In a collectivist society, individuals are integrated from birth into a strong and cohesive internal group that protects them throughout their lives, provided they remain loyal to the group (Hofstede et al., 2010). Organizations in individualistic societies tend to be more concerned about their own self-interests and are reluctant to associate themselves with other social actors (Knein et al., 2020). By contrast, collectivist cultures are constantly concerned about belonging, dependence, and reciprocity, thus promoting social interactions and group-coordinated behaviors (Eby & Dobbins, 1997; Zhao et al., 2008). Organizations with collectivist cultures pursue compromises in a variety of interactional settings to create symbiotic and sustainable relationships that are highly valued by people in this cultural context (Xie et al., 2023). Thus, relative to individualistic cultures, collectivistic cultures can be regarded as catalysts that reinforce the positive impact of prior interorganizational ties on organizational behaviors and performance outcomes.

H2a: Compared with prior ties in individualist cultures, prior ties in collectivist cultures have a stronger positive influence on cooperative behaviors, satisfaction, and relationship performance and a stronger negative influence on opportunistic behaviors.

2.3.2. High/low uncertainty avoidance

Uncertainty avoidance represents the degree to which members of a society feel uncomfortable with uncertainty and ambiguity (Hofstede, 2001). Organizations with high uncertainty avoidance cultures attempt to avoid risks, and their organizational environments tend to be closed and conservative. This attitude weakens the incentives for learning among partners with different backgrounds, and may thus keep organizations away from better partners and opportunities to exchange tacit knowledge (Holloway & Parmigiani, 2016). By contrast, free-flowing environments are more conducive to interorganizational communication and knowledge exchange because such exchanges occur across organizational boundaries (Liu & Ravichandran, 2015). Organizations with low uncertainty avoidance usually encourage information exchange, leading to a high level of motivation to learn (Wang et al., 2021). Consequently, low uncertainty avoidance is likely to enhance the positive effects of prior ties.

H2b: Compared with prior ties under high uncertainty avoidance cultures, prior ties in low uncertainty avoidance cultures have a stronger positive influence on cooperative behaviors, satisfaction, and relationship performance and a stronger negative influence on opportunistic behaviors.

2.3.3. High/low power distance

Power distance is the degree to which people accept unequal power distribution in society (Hofstede, 2001). In high power distance cultures, organizations with greater power tend to take advantage of power to satisfy their requirements (Galinsky et al., 2003; Lu et al., 2020). Repeated exchanges provide them with more opportunities to exert their influence. Organizations with less power regard such power usage of their counterparts as legitimate and are accustomed to meeting their counterparts' requests. Hence, prior ties in high power distance cultures contribute to stronger bonds, which enhance the positive effects of prior ties. By contrast, organizations in low power distance cultures are less receptive to power inequity, which hinders close interaction and information sharing (Cao et al., 2018). Therefore, the foundation through

which prior ties function positively would be damaged. Thus, low power distance is likely to reduce the positive effects of prior ties.

H2c: Compared with prior ties in low power distance cultures, prior ties in high power distance cultures have a stronger positive influence on cooperative behaviors, satisfaction, and relationship performance and a stronger negative influence on opportunistic behaviors.

2.3.4. Developed/Less-developed institutions

Countries with developed institutions can leverage credible regulatory pillars such as legal systems to make contracts more reliable (Liu & Wang, 2020). Hence, organizations can rely on formal contracts to avoid speculative behaviors (Cao & Lumineau, 2015). In such scenarios, the benefits of prior ties may be reduced. Moreover, an effective legal system accentuates the control function of contracts (Child & Möllering, 2003). The emphasis on contractual control undermines trust (Malhotra & Lumineau, 2011), which may further damage the foundation of prior ties. Hence, developed institutions may weaken the positive effects of prior ties. By contrast, in the absence of effective regulatory agencies and enforceable contracts, organizations must turn to relational governance (Cavusgil et al., 2004; Mesquita & Lazzarini, 2008), which highlights the trust and relational norms that can be built through prior ties.

H2d: Compared with prior ties in countries with less-developed institutions, prior ties in countries with developed institutions have a weaker positive influence on cooperative behaviors, satisfaction, and relationship performance and a weaker negative influence on opportunistic behaviors.

2.4. Mediating effects of interorganizational governance mechanisms

Contractual and relational governance play a significant role in interorganizational collaboration. Contractual governance refers to the extent to which interorganizational relationships are governed by formal written contracts that specify the responsibilities and obligations of each party (Ryall & Sampson, 2009; Stefanidis et al., 2023). It can be divided into contract design and contract enforcement (Wang et al., 2023; Zhang et al., 2024).

Contract design is an extrinsic governance strategy that specifies the expected behavior of both parties at the beginning of their cooperation (Huo et al., 2015). First, prior ties are likely to influence contract design, and such impacts can be twofold. Repeated transactions may lead to fewer contractual changes because partner-specific trust and routines develop with repeated collaborations, facilitating the exchange process and reducing the need for contractual modifications (Gulati, 1995; Zaheer et al., 1998). However, previous research suggests that repeated transactions may increase contractual changes (Fudenberg et al., 2009; Poppo et al., 2008a). Partners perceive more value in pursuing contractual changes to maintain better alignment between contract provisions and future interactions. Second, contract design is likely to affect cooperative and opportunistic behaviors. The level of contract detail motivates parties to use different dispute resolution strategies to protect their interests (Lumineau & Malhotra, 2011). As detailed contracts cover clauses on monitoring, inspections, and penalties, parties may feel that speculative behaviors can be detected, leading to serious legal and economic consequences. Thus, detailed contracts serve as deterrents to opportunism (Lumineau & Henderson, 2012; Quanji et al., 2017) and stimulators of cooperative behaviors (Cox & Ireland, 2002). Third, contract design can enhance performance. Detailed contracts provide parties with clear guidelines for transactions that fortify cooperation efficiency. Incorporating penalties for contract violations also prompts parties to ensure good transaction performance. Furthermore, as legal weapons to protect parties' interests, elaborate contracts solidify trust, thereby improving relationship performance (Lee & Chong, 2021) and satisfaction (Poppo & Zenger, 2002).

H3a: Contract design mediates the relationship between prior interorganizational ties and cooperative behaviors/opportunistic behaviors/satisfaction/relationship performance.

Contract enforcement reflects the degree of strictness in contract implementation. It is an ex-post governance strategy that seeks to correct or penalize misconduct that occurs during a transaction (Frazier, 2001). First, prior ties can inhibit contract enforcement. Prior ties clarify the capabilities of parties, thus increasing their confidence in achieving their final objectives. Owing to the belief that a partner is capable of completing the assigned work, the party pays more attention to the evaluation of the final transaction output than to the process (Connelly et al., 2018; Das & Teng, 1996). Chen et al. (2018) found that prior ties can decrease the strictness of contract applications through the mediating role of trust. Second, contract enforcement can influence cooperative and opportunistic behaviors. Under strict contract enforcement, the likelihood and severity of penalties imposed by one party on the other are higher when defaults occur. In this case, the net gains obtained by the other party through opportunism are reduced (Antia et al., 2006). Thus, strict contract enforcement discourages or corrects speculative behaviors (Wei et al., 2022). Parties prefer to adhere strictly to contracts and organizational rules, which not only ensure the effective implementation of contracts but also regulate parties' behaviors and promote cooperation (Fehr & Gächter, 2000). Third, contract enforcement is likely to improve performance. Strict adherence to contracts implies that parties can perform according to a pre-agreed work distribution and responsibility division, which considerably improves management efficiency. The same is particularly true when a crisis occurs because parties can act promptly in accordance with the crisis response process. Such action not only accelerates the settlement of the crisis but also enhances relationship performance (Lv et al., 2023). Additionally, the strict enforcement of contracts prevents parties from engaging in opportunism. It thus further enhances relationship performance and satisfaction (Lv et al., 2023; Quanji et al., 2017).

H3b: Contract enforcement mediates the relationship between prior interorganizational ties and cooperative behaviors/opportunistic behaviors/satisfaction/relationship performance.

Relational governance refers to the extent to which a party is controlled by social relations and shared norms (Poppo et al., 2008b; Zhou & Xu, 2012). Unlike contractual governance, which relies on formal structures and third-party enforcement, relational governance depends on each party's informal structure and self-enforcement. Trust and relational norms are the two most frequently discussed types of relational governance (Griffith & Myers, 2005; Gulati, 1995).

First, prior ties foster relational governance. On the one hand, repeated transactions help determine whether and to what extent the other party can be trusted (Robinson, 1996). Hence, prior ties increase a party's knowledge of its partner and contribute to trust development (Luo, 2002). On the other hand, relational norms provide a reference that guides parties to behave in an expected manner (Liu et al., 2009; Poppo & Zenger, 2002). Relational norms create a social environment based on shared values, rules, and norms. This process usually takes a long time (Lai et al., 2012; Tangpong et al., 2010). Additionally, transactional relationships are characterized by high levels of uncertainty and low levels of trust in the early stages (Thompson, 2017). With the passage of time and an increase in transactional experience, transaction uncertainty decreases, and parties can form common expectations and understanding. Thus, the potential for the parties to establish relational norms increases (Casciaro, 2003; Fink et al., 2008). Therefore, repeated transactions can promote the relational governance of trust and relational norms. Second, relational governance may affect organizational behaviors and performance outcomes. With trust, parties voluntarily share critical information to increase their commitment to their relationships (Gundlach & Cannon, 2010; Yang et al., 2021). Thus, trust limits speculative behaviors and promotes cooperative behaviors (Wang

et al., 2024; Zhong & Sun, 2020). Trust can guarantee parties' cooperative behaviors, even in conflicting situations (Zhang et al., 2023). Moreover, if a party has confidence in its partner, monitoring and auditing become less necessary (Carson et al., 2003), which reduces transaction costs (Zaheer et al., 1998; Zahoor et al., 2021) and enhances relationship performance and satisfaction (Bai et al., 2024). The rationale behind relational norms is similar. Such norms embody guidelines agreed upon by all parties to encourage cooperation and foster a strong sense of solidarity to minimize divergences in expectations and behaviors (Gençtürk & Aulakh, 2007). Convergent expectations, developed alongside relational norms, motivate parties to work together to achieve common goals, thereby enhancing relationship performance and satisfaction.

H3c: Relational governance mediates the relationship between prior interorganizational ties and cooperative behaviors/opportunistic behaviors/satisfaction/relationship performance.

In summary, this study adopts a meta-analytical approach to uncover the overall impact of prior ties on organizational behaviors and performance outcomes, explore the moderating role of institutional environments, and reveal the intrinsic mechanism from the perspective of interorganizational governance mechanisms. The conceptual framework is illustrated in Fig. 1.

3. Methods

3.1. Meta-analysis

3.1.1. Literature search and filtering

We searched for relevant studies in three steps to build the literature dataset. First, we referred to the meta-analyses by Cao and Lumineau (2015) and Wang et al. (2021). The former covers the relationships between contractual/relational governance and performance outcomes, which are included in our conceptual framework. The latter aggregates the relationships between alliance experience and performance outcomes. Alliance experience includes working with the same partner, which is the focus of our study. Both studies conducted a thorough literature search and identified 137 (139 effect sizes; dates no later than 2014) and 143 (143 effect sizes; dates no later than 2017) relevant studies. Therefore, we first obtained their datasets.

Second, the relevant literature was collected by searching for keywords in the Web of Science database. The search terms for prior ties¹ (at least one of which appears in the topic²) included the following: "prior tie*", "prior link*", "prior relation*", "prior alliance*", "prior partner*", "prior exchange*", "prior interaction*", "prior connection*", "repeated tie*", "repeated relation*", "repeated partner*", "repeated exchange*", "repeated interaction*", "previous alliance*", "previous partner*", "previous exchange*", "previous interaction*", "alliance experience", "joint venture experience", "partner* experience", "collaborative experience", "familiarity", "experience with alliance*", "number of alliance*", "total alliance*", "experience with joint venture*", "number of joint venture*", and "total joint venture*". The search terms for contractual governance (at least one of which appears as keywords or title) are as follows: "two contract*", "formal governance", "formal control", "formal mechanism*", "legal bond*", and "legal safeguard*". The search terms for relational governance (at least

¹ We used "topic" to search for studies relevant to prior ties, as the keywords for prior ties are not well-established. For the other constructs, we used "keywords" or "title" rather than "topic" because the latter choice would have yielded too many results for efficient analysis.

² "Topic" means that the search terms appear in the keywords, title, or abstract.

³ Asterisk (*) represents any character. For example, "prior tie*" covers prior tie, prior ties, etc.

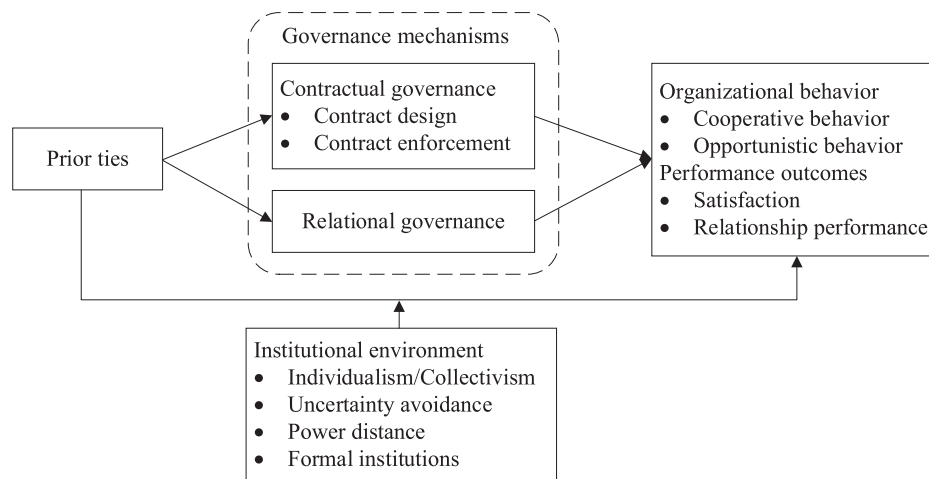


Fig. 1. Conceptual framework.

one of which appears as keywords or title) include the following: “relational governance”, “trust”, “relationalism”, “relational norms”, “cooperative norms”, “informal governance”, “informal control”, “relational mechanism*”, and “social control”. The search terms for organizational behaviors and performance outcomes (at least one of which appears as keywords or title) include the following: “performance”, “satisfact*”, “opportunis*”, “cooperati*”, and “collaborati*”. We also limited the search for a relationship between contractual/relational governance and organizational behaviors/performance outcomes to the period of 2014–2023, as Cao and Lumineau (2015) searched for relevant literature prior to 2014. We did not set a time limit for the search for other relationships. The search yielded 4,643 papers, as shown in Fig. 2 (where N represents the number of papers).

Third, we filtered the resulting articles to identify those to include in our meta-analysis. The criteria for inclusion were as follows: 1) empirical and quantitative; 2) published in journals (excluding conference papers, dissertations, etc.); 3) the unit of analysis should be interorganizational relationships; 4) report at least one of the relationships between the constructs of interest; and 5) report data on sample sizes, correlation coefficients, or other statistics (e.g., Cohen’s d , univariate F , t , η^2) that can be transformed into a correlation coefficient (we emailed the authors if such data are not provided in a paper).

Fourth, we supplemented our literature database by reviewing and screening the citing and cited references of each included study using the above three steps. We then deleted the duplicate papers. To avoid double-counting the effect sizes, we further excluded studies that used the same sample for the same effect size as the others in the literature database.

Applying the above steps resulted in a final dataset of 371 papers that investigated 101,053 interorganizational relationships. One author screened all the literature while the other authors checked the results to avoid missing relevant studies. Similar to a previous meta-analysis (Cao & Lumineau, 2015), we did not restrict the types of interorganizational relationships and covered various types, such as buyer–supplier, outsourcing, and strategic alliances.

3.1.2. Effect size coding

Following standard practices (Lipsey & Wilson, 2001), we developed a protocol to code the relevant information. Three coders participated in the coding. After clarifying the coding content and meanings of the variables, each of the three coders coded 20 randomly selected papers. The results were compared, and inconsistencies were discussed and agreed upon to ensure that all coders had a consistent understanding. Subsequently, each of the three coders coded 141 papers. The percentage of agreement between any two coders ranged from 92.20 % to 93.75 %. The inconsistencies were primarily caused by coder errors. Finally,

one coder completed all the remaining coding work while the other two coders checked the results. Data are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

3.2. Variables

Table 1 lists the definitions and representative measures of the key variables. We coded the correlation coefficients between the independent, dependent, and mediating variables. For the moderating variables, we coded the country in which each study collected the empirical data and converted it to the data we required.

Prior ties: It refers to the contract-based cooperation between two parties prior to the current transaction. Prior ties can be measured by the absence or presence of previous cooperation, the number of previous cooperation, Likert items, and so on.

Organizational behaviors and performance outcomes: Considering the availability of a large sample size for the meta-analysis and the inconsistent results in the current literature, we selected four outcome variables: cooperative behaviors, opportunistic behaviors, satisfaction, and relationship performance. This selection is also consistent with the two meta-analyses by Cao and Lumineau (2015) and Wang et al. (2021), which we built upon to construct the dataset. Cooperative behaviors are coordinated actions taken by parties to achieve mutual benefits. Opportunistic behaviors refer to the acts of seeking self-interest through deception. Satisfaction refers to the degree to which a party is satisfied with the exchange performance. Relationship performance refers to the parties’ performance in terms of quality, cost, delivery, etc.

Moderating variable (institutional environment)⁴: For individualism/collectivism, we referred to the work of Xie et al. (2023) measuring national culture in terms of individualism/collectivism by Hofstede (1984). The table of the individualism index for each country was extracted, and the median value was used to differentiate between individualism and collectivism. For uncertainty avoidance, we referred to the work of Wang et al. (2021) measuring national culture in terms of uncertainty avoidance by Hofstede (1984). The table of the uncertainty avoidance index for each country was extracted, and the median value was used to differentiate between high and low uncertainty avoidance. For power distance, we referred to the work of Cao et al. (2018) measuring national culture in terms of power distance by Hofstede (1984). The table of the power distance index for each country was extracted, and the median value was used to differentiate between high

⁴ We selected institutional environment as the moderating variable because of its important role in governing interorganizational relationships and the availability of data for meta-analysis.

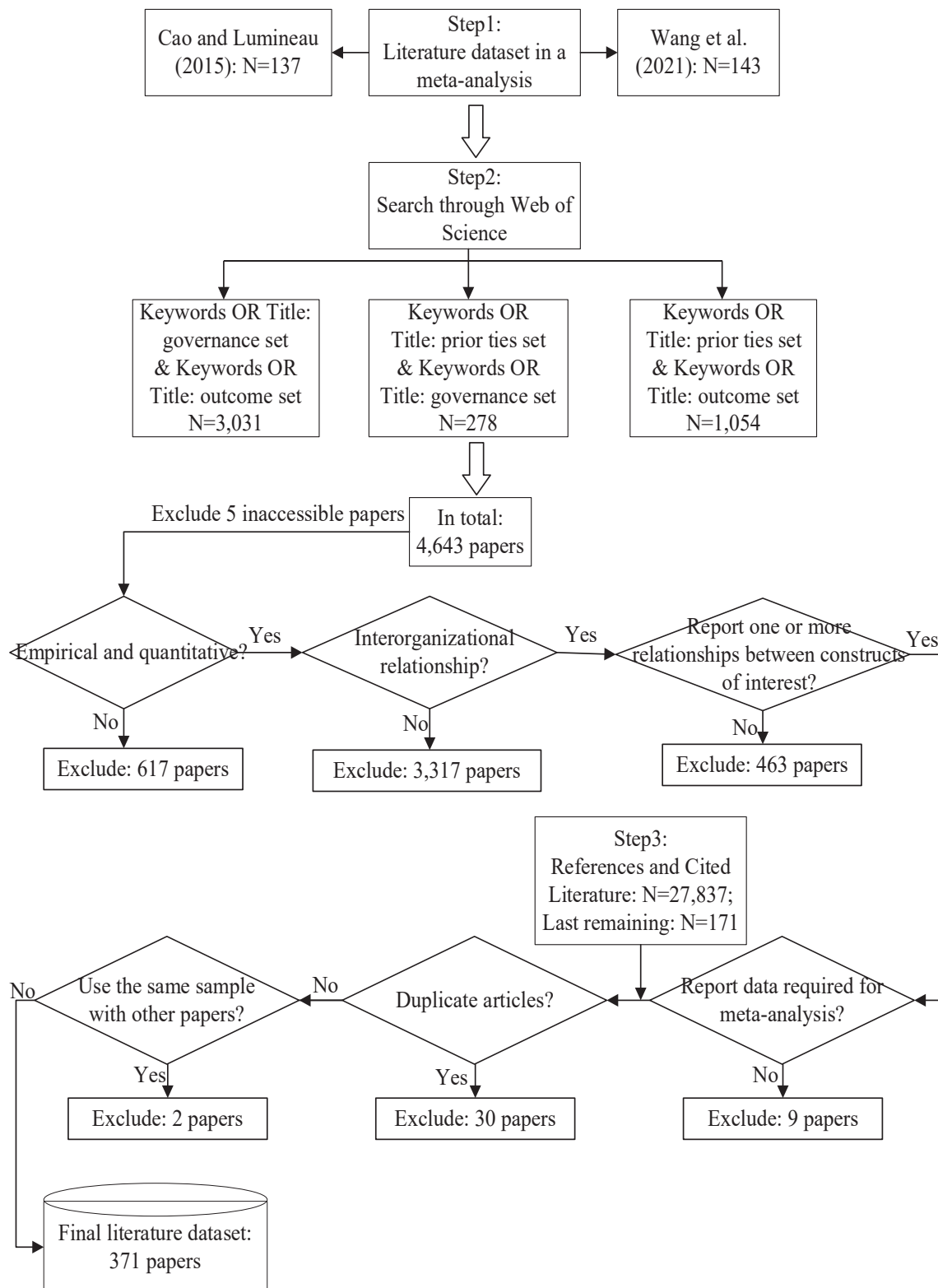


Fig. 2. Literature search and selection process.

and low power distance. For formal institutions, we referred to the work of Wang et al. (2021). The top quartile countries in the World Bank income classification were countries with developed institutions, whereas the remaining countries were those with less-developed institutions.

Mediating variables (contractual and relational governance): Based on Cao and Lumineau (2015), contractual governance refers to the extent to

which interorganizational relationships are governed by formal contracts. Contract design describes the degree to which responsibilities, obligations, penalties, and contingency plans, among others, are set out in formal agreements, whereas contract enforcement captures the degree to which parties act in accordance with contracts. By contrast, relational governance refers to the extent to which interorganizational relationships are governed by informal rules, such as trust and relational

Table 1
Summary of variables.

Constructs	Definition	Representative measures	Representative studies
Prior ties	A previous contractual relationship or cooperation between two parties (Lee & Chong, 2021)	1. Our business partners usually repeat their transactions with us. 2. We do more businesses with our long-term business partners.	Chen et al. (2018), Lui et al. (2006), Luo (2007), Poppo & Zenger (2002)
Organizational behaviors	Cooperative behavior: Coordinated actions taken by parties to achieve mutual benefits (Lui et al., 2009)	1. In most aspects of this relationship, the parties are jointly responsible for getting things done. 2. The party voluntarily does things that are not required in order to pursue better performance. 3. The party is ready to give in on an issue to enable the IJV to achieve its goals, as stated in the contract.	Lui et al. (2009), Luo (2002), Palmatier et al. (2007), Squire et al. (2009), Quanji et al. (2017)
	Opportunistic behavior: "Self-interest seeking with guile" (Williamson, 1975: 26); "The incomplete or distorted disclosure of information, especially to calculated efforts to mislead, distort, disguise, obfuscate, or otherwise confuse" (Williamson, 1985: 47)	1. This partner does not act in accordance to the contract. 2. This partner sometimes breaks an informal agreement to maximize their interests. 3. This partner will try to take advantage of the "hole" of our contract for their interests.	Cavusgil et al. (2004), Liu et al. (2009), Zhou & Xu (2012)
Performance outcomes	Satisfaction: The degree to which the party is satisfied with the exchange performance (Cao & Lumineau, 2015)	1. We are satisfied with the performance of the relationship. 2. We are satisfied with the business performance of the partner. 3. We are satisfied with the quality of the product or service.	Cai & Yang (2008), Lui & Ngo (2004), Poppo & Zenger (2002)
	Relationship performance: A partner's performance in quality, cost, delivery, etc. (Cao & Lumineau, 2015)	Please rate your partner's performance in 1. Competitive price; 2. On-time delivery; 3. Quality of product; 4. Sales, service, and/or technical support.	Cai & Yang (2008), Cannon et al. (2000)
Contractual governance	Contract design: The extent to which roles, obligations, responsibilities, contingency adaptation, legal	1. With this supplier, we have a specific, well-detailed formal agreement. 2. We have formal	Handfield & Bechtel (2002), Huo et al. (2015), Wuyts & Geyskens (2005)

Table 1 (continued)

Constructs	Definition	Representative measures	Representative studies
	penalty, etc. are specified or well-detailed in formal agreements (Abdi & Aulakh, 2012; Luo, 2005)	agreements that detail the obligations of both parties. 3. We have detailed contractual agreements with this supplier.	
	Contract enforcement: The extent to which the parties strictly execute the contract (Huo et al., 2015)	1. Adhering to a detailed contract should be regarded as the most critical to guarantee cooperation. 2. A strict enforcement of detailed contract is essential for controlling the behaviors of all parties. 3. All working rules specified in a detailed contract should be followed. 4. All partners should respect all explicit procedures in a detailed contract.	Burkert et al. (2012), Li et al. (2010), Poppo & Zenger (2002)
Relational governance	The extent to which the relationship is governed by trust, flexibility, solidarity, information exchange, fairness, and other informal rules or procedures (Abdi & Aulakh, 2012; Poppo & Zenger, 2002)	Representative measures for trust: 1. This partner is trustworthy. 2. This partner has always been evenhanded/fair in its negotiations with us. 3. This partner keeps promises it makes to us. 4. This partner has a good reputation and is dependable. Representative measures for relational norms: First-order construct measured by norm items OR second-order construct measured by three first-order constructs: information exchange, flexibility, and solidarity.	Burkert et al. (2012), Lui et al. (2006), Zhang & Zhou (2013) Jap & Ganesan (2000), Lumineau & Oxley (2012), Yang et al. (2012)

norms.

3.3. Analytical process

As we did not assume homogeneity across studies, we employed random-effects meta-analysis procedures. We followed the HOMA meta-analytic procedure (Hedges & Olkin, 2014) to aggregate the effect size in each study and assess the overall effect size of the relationships between the constructs of interest. Before the calculations, we adjusted the effect

sizes for reliability using the formula proposed by Hunter and Schmidt (2004). For studies with missing information on measurement reliability, we used the average reliability instead. If a study used multiple measures for a single construct and reported separate effects for each measure, we averaged the results to yield a single effect (Hunter & Schmidt, 2004). We also calculated the Q and I^2 statistics to test for heterogeneity and the potential presence of moderating variables. The test statistics for within-group heterogeneity (Q_w) and between-group heterogeneity (Q_B) were reported accordingly. We utilized CMA software (version 3.0) to process the calculations.

Three methods were used to test for publication bias. First, we mapped the funnel plot of each effect size to check symmetry (Borenstein et al., 2021). No significant asymmetry was observed. Second, we derived Fail-safe N for each tested relationship. Except for the prior ties–contract design/contract enforcement/cooperative behavior relationships and the contract enforcement–cooperative behavior relationship, all Fail-safe N values exceeded $5k + 10$, which is a rule of thumb that suggests the little impact of publication bias (Rhoades & Eisenberger, 2002; Rosenthal, 1979). Third, we used the trim-and-fill method (Duval & Tweedie, 2000) to assess all the relationships and correct for publication bias. Consequently, the estimated number of studies missing owing to publication was zero, suggesting that publication bias was not a serious issue.

4. Results

4.1. Main effects of prior ties on organizational behaviors/performance outcomes

The main effects of prior ties are summarized in Table 2. The correlation coefficient between prior ties and cooperative behaviors was 0.1817 ($p < 0.05$), which indicated a positive correlation; thus, H1a was supported. The correlation coefficient between prior ties and opportunistic behaviors was -0.1029 ($p < 0.05$), which indicated a negative correlation; thus, H1b was supported. The correlation coefficient between prior ties and satisfaction was 0.1217 ($p < 0.05$), which indicated a positive relationship; thus, H1c was supported. The correlation coefficient between prior ties and relationship performance was 0.0687 ($p < 0.05$), which indicated a positive correlation; thus H1d was supported.

4.2. Moderating effects of institutional environments

The moderating effects of institutional environments are presented in Table 3. For the moderating effect of individualism/collectivism, the correlation between prior ties and opportunistic behaviors was 0.121 (95 % C.I. = $-0.026/0.262$) in countries with individualistic cultures and -0.172 (95 % C.I. = $-0.249/-0.094$) in countries with collectivistic cultures, with significant between-group heterogeneity ($Q_B = 11.975$, $p = 0.001$). Thus, individualism/collectivism moderated the relationship between prior ties and opportunistic behaviors. Second, the correlation between prior ties and satisfaction was 0.070 (95 % C.I. = $-0.008/0.147$) in countries with individualistic cultures and less than 0.172 (95 % C.I. = $0.078/0.263$) in countries with collectivistic cultures,

although heterogeneity between groups was insignificant ($Q_B = 3.693$, $p = 0.158$). Thus, individualism/collectivism did not moderate the relationship between prior ties and satisfaction. Third, the correlation between prior ties and relationship performance was 0.041 (95 % C.I. = $-0.005/0.087$) in countries with individualistic cultures and less than 0.122 (95 % C.I. = $0.068/0.175$) in countries with collectivistic cultures, although the heterogeneity between groups was insignificant ($Q_B = 5.420$, $p = 0.067$). Therefore, individualism/collectivism did not moderate the relationship between prior ties and relationship performance. In summary, H2a was partially supported.

Based on a similar analysis, uncertainty avoidance moderated the relationship between prior ties and opportunistic behaviors but did not moderate the relationship between prior ties and relationship performance. Therefore, H2b was partially supported. The moderating effects of power distance were insignificant, hence the rejection of H2c. Formal institutions moderated the relationship between prior ties and opportunistic behaviors but did not moderate the relationship between prior ties and satisfaction/relationship performance. Thus, H2d was partially supported.

4.3. Mediating effects of interorganizational governance mechanisms

First, we tested whether contract design mediates the relationship between prior ties and organizational behaviors/performance outcomes. As Table 4 shows, the t -value of the indirect effect of prior ties on cooperative behaviors was 2.271 ($|t| > 1.96$, $p < 0.05$), thus supporting the existence of a mediating effect. Moreover, the t -value of the overall effect was 8.301 ($|t| > 1.96$, $p < 0.05$), indicating that contract design had a partial mediating effect on the relationship between prior ties and cooperative behaviors. Similarly, the results showed that contract design partially mediated the relationship between prior ties and opportunistic behaviors/satisfaction/relationship performance. Therefore, H3a was supported.

Based on a similar analysis, contract enforcement did not mediate the relationship between prior ties and organizational behaviors/performance outcomes. Hence, H3b was not supported. Relational governance had a partial mediating effect on the relationship between prior ties and organizational behaviors/performance outcomes. Therefore, H3c was supported.

5. Discussion

5.1. Are prior ties generally advantageous or disadvantageous?

An aggregation of empirical evidence demonstrates that prior ties are generally beneficial in terms of fostering cooperation, hindering opportunism, and enhancing parties' satisfaction and exchange performance. Repeated exchanges provide parties with opportunities to learn from each other and become familiar with each other's capabilities and working habits. Consequently, they learn how to complement each other's advantages and maximize collaboration efficiency. Moreover, considering the need to maintain long-term cooperation, parties are likely to pursue mutual benefits. Past experiences also enable parties to

Table 2
Relationships between prior ties and organizational behavior/performance outcomes.

Relationship	K	N	$\rho(p)$	SD ρ	Z	95 % C.I. (L, H)	Q(p)	I^2	Fail-safe N
PT-CO	4	990	0.1817(0.0033)	0.104	2.9368	(0.0610,0.2971)	10.443(0.015)	0.713	28
PT-OP	19	3839	$-0.1029(0.0136)$	0.165	-2.4682	$(-0.1832,-0.0213)$	114.774(0.000)	0.843	224
PT-SA	13	3795	0.1217(0.0000)	0.092	3.6950	(0.0574,0.1851)	37.875(0.000)	0.683	124
PT-OU	87	34,491	0.0687(0.0000)	0.122	4.5458	(0.0391,0.0981)	555.330(0.000)	0.845	2174

Notes: PT: prior ties; CO: cooperative behaviors; OP: opportunistic behaviors; SA: satisfaction; OU: relationship performance; K: number of effect sizes; N: total sample size; $\rho(p)$: corrected true correlation coefficient (probability of p); SD ρ : standard deviation of ρ ; Z: Fisher's Z statistic, 95 % C.I. (L, H): 95 % confidence interval of ρ (lower bound, higher bound); Q(p): heterogeneity test statistic (probability of Q); I^2 : scale free index of heterogeneity; Fail-safe N = the measure of non-publication bias.

Table 3
Moderating effects of institutional environment.

Relationship		K	N	ρ	SD ρ	Z	95 % C.I. (L, H)	Q _W (p)	I ²	Q _B (p)
Individualism/Collectivism										
PT-OP	Individualism	5	591	0.121	0.144	1.619	(−0.026,0.262)	13.284 (0.010)	0.699	11.975 (0.001)
	Collectivism	14	3248	−0.172	0.135	−4.271	(−0.249,−0.094)	66.582 (0.000)	0.805	
PT-SA	Individualism	7	2623	0.070	0.056	1.760	(−0.008,0.147)	11.290 (0.080)	0.469	3.693 (0.158)
	Collectivism	5	887	0.172	0.110	3.573	(0.078,0.263)	12.110 (0.017)	0.670	
PT-OU	Individualism	39	19,836	0.041	0.087	1.767	(−0.005,0.087)	158.102 (0.000)	0.760	5.420 (0.067)
	Collectivism	27	7126	0.122	0.171	4.403	(0.068,0.175)	222.172 (0.000)	0.883	
High/Low uncertainty avoidance										
PT-OP	High uncertainty avoidance	4	482	0.142	0.173	1.658	(−0.026,0.302)	13.003 (0.005)	0.769	10.215 (0.001)
	Low uncertainty avoidance	15	3357	−0.160	0.137	−3.970	(−0.237,−0.082)	71.588 (0.000)	0.804	
PT-OU	High uncertainty avoidance	19	4234	0.052	0.171	1.527	(−0.005,0.087)	130.788 (0.000)	0.862	0.694 (0.707)
	Low uncertainty avoidance	45	21,629	0.081	0.107	3.779	(0.068,0.175)	246.520 (0.000)	0.822	
High/Low power distance										
PT-OP	High power distance	15	3217	−0.118	0.165	−2.522	(−0.208,−0.026)	93.735 (0.000)	0.851	0.546 (0.460)
	Low power distance	4	622	−0.042	0.173	−0.454	(−0.220,0.139)	16.449 (0.001)	0.818	
PT-OU	High power distance	28	7244	0.115	0.169	4.224	(0.062,0.168)	221.459 (0.000)	0.878	4.569 (0.102)
	Low power distance	36	18,619	0.039	0.090	1.592	(−0.009,0.087)	151.760 (0.000)	0.769	
PT-SA	High power distance	4	699	0.140	0.113	2.305	(0.021,0.254)	9.207 (0.027)	0.674	1.103 (0.603)
	Low power distance	8	2811	0.100	0.086	2.382	(0.018,0.181)	21.036 (0.004)	0.667	
Developed/Less-developed institutions										
PT-OP	Developed institutions	5	591	0.121	0.144	1.619	(−0.026,0.262)	13.284 (0.010)	0.699	11.975 (0.001)
	Less-developed institutions	14	3248	−0.172	0.135	−4.271	(−0.249,−0.094)	66.582 (0.000)	0.805	
PT-SA	Developed institutions	7	2623	0.070	0.056	1.760	(−0.008,0.147)	11.290 (0.080)	0.469	3.693 (0.158)
	Less-developed institutions	5	887	0.172	0.110	3.573	(0.078,0.263)	12.110 (0.017)	0.670	
PT-OU	Developed institutions	42	20,496	0.047	0.107	2.107	(0.003,0.091)	229.040 (0.000)	0.821	3.928 (0.140)
	Less-developed institutions	22	5367	0.120	0.152	3.953	(0.061,0.178)	135.649 (0.000)	0.845	

Notes: 1) PT: prior ties; OP: opportunistic behaviors; SA: satisfaction; OU: relationship performance; K: number of effect sizes; N: total sample size; ρ : corrected true correlation coefficient; SD ρ : standard deviation of ρ ; Z: Fisher's Z statistic, 95% C.I. (L, H): 95% confidence interval of ρ (lower bound, higher bound); Q_W(p): Cochran's within-group homogeneity test statistic (probability of Q_W); I²: scale free index of heterogeneity; Q_B(p): Cochran's between-group homogeneity test statistic (probability of Q_B). 2) In countries with collectivist and individualistic cultures, fewer than three studies have investigated prior ties and cooperative behaviors. In countries with high uncertainty avoidance, fewer than three studies have investigated prior ties and cooperative behaviors (or satisfaction). In countries with highly developed and less-developed institutions, fewer than three studies have investigated prior ties and cooperative behaviors. Therefore, they were not included in this table (Cao & Lumineau, 2015).

predict each other's actions and motivations. Appropriate measures can then be taken to avoid deviant behaviors. Therefore, the overall impact of prior ties is favorable.

Some studies have found that repeated exchanges adversely influence organizations (e.g., Li et al., 2008; Ren et al., 2024; Wuyts & Geyskens, 2005). Their rationale lies on the dark side of familiarity. For example, a party can take advantage of its knowledge about its partner's working routines accumulated from long-term interactions and behave opportunistically by exploiting its partner's loopholes and weaknesses. Furthermore, prior ties may weaken the strictness of contract execution because parties believe that they can rely on informal rules developed over time. However, this loose managerial style also stimulates opportunism. Repeated exchanges may also lead to inertia regarding contract changes. Therefore, contracts may include unreasonable or inappropriate stipulations that impede efficient interorganizational collaboration. Nevertheless, although inconsistencies exist in the literature, our study reveals the generally positive influence of prior ties.

5.2. Under which institutional environment do prior ties show an attenuated effect?

Moderating variables illustrate how the relationships between two variables change under different settings. When examining the influence of prior ties, previous studies have overlooked the role of moderating variables (e.g., Wang et al., 2017) or introduced particular moderating variables, such as task uncertainty and dependence asymmetry (Ren et al., 2024). Our study enriches this stream of research by testing the moderating effects of institutional environments.

Regarding individualism/collectivism, the positive impact of prior ties on relationship performance and satisfaction is greater in countries with collectivist cultures than in those with individualist cultures. Collectivist cultures focus on belonging, dependence, and mutual benefits (Eby & Dobbins, 1997). Therefore, in collectivist countries, organizations are more inclined to integrate themselves into various social networks, thereby enhancing knowledge dissemination. This is beneficial for relationship performance and satisfaction (Engelen et al., 2014). Furthermore, prior ties in collectivist countries help inhibit opportunism, whereas those in individualist countries do not, indicating the attenuated effect of familiarity. This outcome may be due to the

⁵ We did not find evidence of the dark side of prior ties in terms of promoting opportunism. Instead, the impact of prior ties on decreasing opportunistic behaviors in general becomes insignificant in certain subgroups, implying an offset of the benefits of prior ties. To ensure precise wording, we used “attenuation” rather than “dark side”.

Table 4

Mediating effects of contract design, contract enforcement, and relational governance.

Relationship		Path coefficients	(Standard error)	t
Contract design				
PT-CD-CO	Total effects of PT on CO	0.182	(0.022)	8.301
	Total effects of PT on CD	0.051	(0.022)	2.294
	Indirect effects of PT on CO	0.017	(0.007)	2.271
PT-CD-OP	Total effects of PT on OP	−0.103	(0.013)	−7.673
	Total effects of PT on CD	0.051	(0.013)	3.788
	Indirect effects of PT on OP	−0.008	(0.002)	−3.591
PT-CD-SA	Total effects of PT on SA	0.122	(0.014)	8.724
	Total effects of PT on CD	0.051	(0.014)	3.634
	Indirect effects of PT on SA	0.015	(0.004)	3.586
PT-CD-OU	Total effects of PT on OU	0.069	(0.009)	7.781
	Total effects of PT on CD	0.051	(0.009)	5.837
	Indirect effects of PT on OU	0.017	(0.003)	5.775
Contract enforcement				
PT-CE-CO	Total effects of PT on CO	0.182	(0.025)	7.213
	Total effects of PT on CE	0.005	(0.026)	0.195
	Indirect effects of PT on CO	0.000	(0.002)	−0.195
PT-CE-OP	Total effects of PT on OP	−0.103	(0.015)	−6.882
	Total effects of PT on CE	0.005	(0.015)	0.333
	Indirect effects of PT on OP	−0.001	(0.002)	−0.332
PT-CE-SA	Total effects of PT on SA	0.122	(0.017)	7.280
	Total effects of PT on CE	0.005	(0.017)	0.297
	Indirect effects of PT on SA	0.001	(0.002)	0.297
PT-CE-OU	Total effects of PT on OU	0.069	(0.010)	7.094
	Total effects of PT on CE	0.005	(0.010)	0.515
	Indirect effects of PT on OU	0.002	(0.004)	0.515
Relational governance				
PT-RG-CO	Total effects of PT on CO	0.182	(0.020)	9.131
	Total effects of PT on RG	0.134	(0.020)	6.682
	Indirect effects of PT on CO	0.080	(0.012)	6.576
PT-RG-OP	Total effects of PT on OP	−0.102	(0.011)	−9.048
	Total effects of PT on RG	0.134	(0.011)	11.826
	Indirect effects of PT on OP	−0.047	(0.004)	−11.133
PT-RG-SA	Total effects of PT on SA	0.122	(0.012)	10.444
	Total effects of PT on RG	0.134	(0.012)	11.518

Table 4 (continued)

Relationship		Path coefficients	(Standard error)	t
PT-RG-OU	Indirect effects of PT on SA	0.094	(0.008)	11.412
	Total effects of PT on OU	0.069	(0.006)	11.149
	Total effects of PT on RG	0.134	(0.006)	21.892
	Indirect effects of PT on OU	0.074	(0.003)	21.438

Notes: 1) PT: prior ties; CO: cooperative behaviors; OP: opportunistic behaviors; SA: satisfaction; OU: relationship performance; CD: contract design. 2) $|t| > 1.96$ means $p < 0.05$, $|t| > 2.58$ means $p < 0.01$, $|t| > 3.29$ means $p < 0.001$.

tendency of organizations in individualistic cultures to focus on their own interests and their reluctance to establish ties with others (Knein et al., 2020). These characteristics limit knowledge dissemination and information exchange (Sarooghi et al., 2015). Consequently, the benefit of prior ties in reducing speculative behaviors disappears.

Regarding uncertainty avoidance, prior ties hinder opportunism in countries with low uncertainty avoidance but not in countries with high uncertainty avoidance. The beneficial role of prior ties in countries with low uncertainty avoidance is also embodied in the greater enhancement of relationship performance than that in countries with high uncertainty avoidance. Countries with high uncertainty avoidance usually have closed and conservative environments that weaken bilateral learning. By contrast, countries with low uncertainty avoidance encourage communication, prompting higher levels of motivation to learn (Wang et al., 2021), which facilitates relationship performance and discourages opportunistic behaviors.

We did not find a moderating effect of power distance. This result indicates that the influence of national culture can be dimension-specific, thus echoing previous literature. For example, Cao et al. (2018) revealed that individualism/collectivism and power distance moderate the relationship between exchange hazards and contractual governance, whereas uncertainty avoidance does not. Similarly, Cao and Lumineau (2015) showed that the relationship between contractual and relational governance is significantly moderated by individualism/collectivism and power distance but not by uncertainty avoidance.

Regarding formal institutions, the positive impact of prior ties on relationship performance and satisfaction is greater in countries with less-developed institutions than in those with developed institutions. Prior ties in countries with less-developed institutions also show an advantage in reducing opportunism, whereas prior ties in countries with developed institutions do not. This difference is mainly due to the immature legal systems in less-developed countries. Even if a contract is signed to protect the implementation of a transaction, contract enforceability could be weak, resulting in limited protection against opportunism. In this case, repeated transactions allow parties to know each other, thereby increasing confidence in collaboration and promoting communication. This condition contributes to improved relationship performance and satisfaction and reduced opportunism. By contrast, developed countries have sound legal systems and strong, enforceable laws. Even for first-time cooperations, parties can rely on enforceable contracts to regulate behaviors. Thus, the dark side of prior ties may be prominent: prior ties enable parties to be more familiar with each other's behavioral patterns so that they can exploit loopholes more conveniently (Ren et al., 2024). Consequently, the advantage of prior ties would be limited and counteracted. Furthermore, a robust legal system highlights contractual control, which undermines mutual trust (Cao & Lumineau, 2015). This condition also hinders the benefits of prior ties.

5.3. Do contractual and relational governance play the same mediating role?

This study revealed the partial mediating roles of contract design and relational governance in explaining how prior ties function. However, contract enforcement did not play the same mediating role as predicted. One possible explanation is that for both dimensions of contractual governance, parties are more concerned about contract design than enforcement. Contract design can provide formal guarantees and increase confidence in cooperation. Because of detailed contracts used as backup support, parties can choose flexible enforcement as needed during the transaction process. Therefore, the influence of prior ties is mainly reflected in contract design. This result is in line with the finding of [Huo et al. \(2016\)](#) that managers tend to draft detailed contracts but do not necessarily use them to solve problems. In other words, managers usually place greater emphasis on contract design than on enforcement.

Another possible explanation is that repeated transactions may have both positive and negative effects on contract enforcement, ultimately leading to a tradeoff and an insignificant relationship. On the one hand, prior ties promote amicable relationships, leading to flexible and soft contract enforcement to avoid relationship damage ([Chen et al., 2018](#)). On the other hand, prior ties offer parties the opportunity to adjust or improve contracts. Hence, contracts are more likely to align with the characteristics of current transactions. For example, if a partner exhibits speculative behaviors in past exchanges, the corresponding penalties can be stipulated in the current contract. Therefore, the parties are willing to strictly implement the contract because they believe that it benefits both parties ([Wang et al., 2017](#)).

The literature also shows that the impact of prior ties on contract design is twofold. Repeated transactions lead to mutual understanding, learning, and accumulated transactional experience. Parties tend to embody what they have learned from each other in subsequent contracts ([Mayer & Argyres, 2004](#); [Ryall & Sampson, 2009](#); [Wang et al., 2019](#); [Xing et al., 2021](#)), resulting in more detailed contracts. Meanwhile, prior ties foster mutual trust and working routines, which decrease the need for contract modifications ([Gulati, 1995](#); [Zaheer et al., 1998](#)). This condition can result in cursory contracts. Repeated transactions may also generate interorganizational inertia when updating contract provisions ([Mayer & Bercovitz, 2008](#)). Owing to this double logic, the current literature shows inconsistent findings. For example, [Wang et al. \(2017\)](#) found that prior ties do not influence the complexity of contractual control, whereas [Ryall and Sampson \(2009\)](#) identified a positive correlation between prior ties and the complexity of contractual monitoring. Nevertheless, by integrating a large amount of empirical data, our study reveals that prior ties have a positive overall impact on contract design.

While much of the literature supports the benefits of relational governance (c.f., [Cao & Lumineau, 2015](#)), some recent developments reveal the dark side of close business relationships. For example, [Forkmann et al. \(2022\)](#) argued that intraorganizational agency trust and interorganizational trust weaken behavior-based controls, creating an environment that makes boundary spanner corruption more likely to occur. Similarly, [Pillai et al. \(2023\)](#) pointed out that boundary spanners' social psychological processes can generate the dark side effects of interorganizational relationships. [Wang et al. \(2024\)](#) revealed that trust asymmetry, that is, when buyer trust exceeds supplier trust, can trigger increased supplier opportunism. By contrast, our meta-analysis shows that prior ties can increase cooperative behaviors/satisfaction/relationship performance and decrease opportunistic behaviors via relational governance. Although we did not identify the dark side of relational governance, we envisaged opportunities to explore this issue further in different contexts.

6. Contributions to theory and practice

6.1. Theoretical contributions

First, this study deepens the understanding of the influence of prior ties in business management and bridges the gap caused by the lack of integrated empirical evidence. Although many studies have explored the consequences of repeated exchanges, their findings have been inconsistent. These controversies not only limit knowledge accumulation regarding prior ties but also raise doubts about the generalizability of prior research. This study takes advantage of meta-analyses and contributes to the field by revealing the overall positive influence of prior ties.

Second, we clarify the boundary conditions for prior ties from an institutional perspective. We analyze the moderating role of the four types of institutional environment and find that prior ties have advantages and disadvantages in different institutional contexts. The findings support the argument that different institutional environments are important reasons behind the inconsistent results of previous studies. Thus, this study not only indicates the complexity of how prior ties function but also provides important clues to the understanding of divergent findings in interorganizational relationship management.

Third, this study elucidates the internal logic of how prior ties affect organizational behaviors and performance outcomes from the perspective of interorganizational governance mechanisms. The results show that prior ties can exert both direct and indirect influence through two key governance mechanisms: contract design and relational governance. This finding helps open the black box of how repeated transactions link organizational behaviors and performance outcomes and deepens our understanding of intermediate mechanisms.

6.2. Practical contributions

First, this study enhances business managers' understanding of the pros and cons of repeated transactions and provides theoretical support for selecting partners in different contexts. Generally, repeated transactions are encouraged because of their benefits in enhancing cooperation, satisfaction, and relationship performance and in decreasing opportunism. However, managers should be aware of the institutional environments in which these exchanges are embedded. Parties in countries with collectivist cultures, low uncertainty avoidance, or less-developed institutions should actively engage in repeated exchanges if conditions permit because the positive side of prior ties can be strengthened in such contexts. By contrast, parties in countries with collectivist cultures, high uncertainty avoidance, or developed institutions should not limit themselves to partners with a transactional history and should instead choose the most appropriate partners based on multiple factors, such as quality assurance, price advantage, and warranty reliability. In particular, our study shows the nonsignificant impact of prior ties in such institutional contexts. In other words, the benefits of reducing opportunistic behaviors are attenuated. If managers must select partners with previous experience and no better choices are available, measures should be taken to avoid negative consequences. For example, they can prioritize the reputation factor and select the most honest and trustworthy partners based on their interactive histories. Active information sharing and reciprocity during cooperative processes should be encouraged to foster bilateral trust and solidarity.

Second, business managers should be fully aware of the critical roles played by contract design and relational governance in repeated transactions. Owing to detailed contracts, established trust, and relational norms, parties can take advantage of the benefits of prior ties and further enhance collaboration and performance. Thus, when engaging in repeated transactions, managers should invest more effort in improving contract provisions to ensure that the rights and interests of both parties are fully protected. Based on lessons learned from past transactions, managers can incorporate guidelines for handling unexpected events

encountered in previous cooperation into current contracts. Meanwhile, previously ill-designed contract clauses should be improved, and new clauses that can enhance the effectiveness and efficiency of cooperation should be added. Managers should focus on establishing and maintaining bilateral trust. Problems can be solved through relational norms, such as open communication and reciprocal strategies, rather than through strict enforcement. In summary, the beneficial effects of prior ties can be maximized through detailed contracts and mature relational approaches.

7. Limitations and future research opportunities

This study has some limitations. First, limited by information in the literature, we focused only on four outcome variables and the moderating role of institutional environments. An in-depth exploration of other outcome variables (e.g., formalization, centralization, and vertical integration) and moderating mechanisms (e.g., expected relationship length and type of prior ties) is undoubtedly a rich avenue for future research. Future empirical research could aim to provide background information, including data on the correlation between variables and the sampling and research context, as exhaustively as possible. Full disclosure of these data will provide richer information for future meta-analyses and help accurately reveal the complex influence of prior ties.

Second, although we used various methods to collect the relevant literature, covering all studies (e.g., unpublished grey literature) was impossible. This limitation is a general characteristic of meta-analyses. After more relevant studies are published, the literature database can be enriched. Future meta-analyses should further examine the robustness and generalizability of our results.

Third, meta-analyses are primarily based on correlations rather than causation. Future research should adopt experimental designs or longitudinal research methods to understand the causal relationships between these variables more accurately. This approach will help us gain a deeper understanding of the mechanisms behind the effects of prior ties and provide stronger theoretical support for business management practices.

Fourth, our meta-analytic results showed that the general impact of prior ties on contract design was positive but nonsignificant on contract enforcement. We also discussed the potential positive and negative mechanisms underlying these relationships. Future research could examine the relationships between prior ties and contract design/enforcement, particularly focusing on moderating variables. The accumulated empirical evidence can be used to further investigate situations in which positive or negative impacts dominate. Furthermore, we revealed the specific institutional environments in which the benefits of prior ties disappear. Probably because of the limited sample size in these subgroups, we did not find evidence of the dark side of prior ties regarding increasing opportunism. Instead, its benefit in reducing opportunism is attenuated. Scholars in these institutional environments are invited to collect more relevant data that can contribute to identifying more significant relationships in future meta-analyses. Scholars are also encouraged to explore the consequences of prior ties in other contexts to further enrich the boundary conditions of prior ties.

Fifth, limited by the meta-analytic method, we could not examine the impact of endogeneity issues on our findings. Some studies in our dataset considered endogeneity issues while others did not. This limitation of the existing literature may bias our understanding of the influence of prior ties. We encourage future studies to consider endogeneity issues at the beginning of their research design and use typical methods (e.g., two-stage least squares models) to control such issues. Doing so will minimize the risk of biased coefficients caused by endogeneity issues in future meta-analyses.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Lihan Zhang: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft,

Validation, Supervision, Project administration, Methodology, Funding acquisition, Conceptualization. **Bo Liu:** Writing – original draft, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis. **Yongcheng Fu:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Methodology, Funding acquisition, Conceptualization. **Sujuan Zhang:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Funding acquisition. **Wenqian Guo:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Funding acquisition.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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Lihan Zhang, is currently an associate professor in the School of Economics and Management at the Hebei University of Technology, China. She received the Ph.D. degree in the management of projects from the University of Manchester, U.K. in 2018. Her research interests include interorganizational governance mechanisms and meta-analysis.

Bo Liu, is currently working toward the master's degree in management science and engineering with the School of Economics and Management, Hebei University of Technology, Tianjin, China. Her research focuses on repeated exchanges and meta-analysis.

Yongcheng Fu, is currently an associate professor in the College of Management and Economics, Tianjin University. He received his Ph.D. degree in business and management from Alliance Manchester Business School, the University of Manchester, U.K. in 2019. His research focuses on business management and meta-analysis.

Sujuan Zhang, is currently a lecturer in School of Project Management at the University of Sydney, Australia. She received the Ph.D. degree in project management from University of Hong Kong, China in 2020. Her research interests include project management and interorganizational relationship governance.

Wenqian Guo, is currently a lecturer in School of Economics and Management at Beijing Jiaotong University, China. She received the Ph.D. degree in management science and engineering from Tianjin University, China in 2022. Her research interests include business management and interorganizational governance mechanisms.